

Introduction

Often we feel that everyone who uses technology is just like us – people who have similar backgrounds, similar tastes and most importantly people a similar age group. This couldn't be farther from the truth. There is an entire user-group we simply overlook – kids! Every thought about it? Your niece, nephew, child, younger sibling, neighbour's kids, they're all users of technology.

The current generation of adults have only adopted the habit of technology in the last 20 years. However, for those of us who were born after the proliferation of internet mobile devices, things are very different. In this technology driven atmosphere it isn't easy to know what is and isn't right for these young ones all around us. Knowing what are the safe routes to technology literacy falls firstly in the hands of adult caregivers. So whether you're a parent, sibling or even a babysitter - educating yourself is the first step. So gather around boys and girls and take in this month's Fast Track to Kids Tech which brings you techno tips for tiny tykes.

We begin by taking an overview of what constitutes “kids tech”. Where does adult tech end and kids tech begin? What are the resources available for adults to know what is the right choice? And what is the cultural difference between children born into technology and their parents? We answer all these question and more as we journey into the world of digital natives and their relationship with technology. We also devote chapters that address a few of the concerns caregivers should have when leaving their young ones with mobile internet technology. Using case studies and other empirical data we advise you on the fundamentals of technology and its effects on the security of your children.

In subsequent chapters we chart a step by step plan or “baby steps” towards technology acclimatisation. In addition, we assess and suggest various different user interfaces and operating systems for mobiles and PCs which can be used to create a child-centric computer. This section not